from behind. He had one man dead and a few wounded. Low on ammunition and reserves, it was a matter of time before the Chinese would overrun his position, so he decided to break contact and withdraw his men.

The third Chinese column approached High Ground via the Indus Valley. While some troops established an ambush at Lagankhel, the main party assembled on the Leh road at a point called the loop, where they assembled their mortars and fired at High Ground. The first mortar bomb landed at 7.30 a.m.

Through the day, the Chinese kept bombarding High Ground, intermittently infiltrating the Indian positions and exchanging fire with the defenders who were well entrenched. As the day wore on, the situation began to wear on Major Sharma's mind. News of the Chinese having established roadblocks near Lagankhel and the fact that there would be no reinforcements convinced him that should he dig in and fight he would definitely be overwhelmed. Sharma was also aware of a fourth Chinese column that had captured Charding-la earlier in the morning. Should this column also arrive at High Ground, he and his men would be caught in a pincer.

The officer lost his nerve and chose to extricate his men; once again the Chinese were not tested against reasonable defences. Sharma left High Ground with 150 men under the cover of darkness, leaving Lieutenant Siddhu, an Engineer officer, to destroy all the equipment and get the seriously wounded out in the handful of vehicles at his disposal. Sharma's failure to keep the men under his charge together resulted in a lot of confusion and he was the last man to be rescued in the middle of November from Hanle where he was hiding. Fortunately, almost everyone made it back to Koyul.

The last to leave High Ground was Lieutenant Siddhu. After Sharma's departure, he meticulously went about destroying all the equipment. After loading as many men as he could into the three 3-tonners, he dispatched the remaining men with instructions to follow the Koyul Chu until they got to Battalion HQ. He then got into the leading jeep, having fitted LMGs on all the vehicles. His convoy, driving without lights, fired in all directions and bashed through the Chinese barricades once it reached the Lagankhel area.

Siddhu's arrival at Koyul in the early hours of 28 October and his first-hand account of the Chinese ingress gave Brigadier Grewal a fair assessment of the situation in his new command. At dawn, the Indians could